

MISSION REPORT

24 - 28 June 1985

OXFORD - SHRIVENHAM - LONDON

file
ORG 232/1 '85

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2. ORG 231/6 (25)
3. ORG 23/6 (23)

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24 JUL. 1985

UNDRO Registry

1. OXFORD Polytechnic - Disaster Management Workshop

1.1 This three week workshop was the first of three disaster planning "modules". Eighteen officials of twelve nationalities participated (including two officials for whom UNDRO arranged participation). The instruction was intensive, involving twenty instructional staff and visiting speakers on both sudden and long-onset disasters. The University of Wisconsin is to give credit towards its disaster management diploma to those who took a final exam. Details on the course are in the file.

1.2 I attended sessions on 24 and 25 June, respectively devoted to Ethiopia and Sudan - along with Nicholas Russel and UNHCR-Sudan Logistics consultant Michael Day Thompson whom I had had invited. In this context I was asked to speak on UNDRO, and on the UN in disasters, notably with respect to Africa.

1.3 This was UNDRO's first participation in the Workshop, now in its fourth year. Based on this experience, and in view of the international and professional character of the Workshop continued support and participation seems warranted. UNDRO might also make greater use of the Workshop in its disaster preparedness activities, drawing on OFDA, or British Council financial support as was done for El Mansour, Head of RICSU, Khartoum. As a personal comment, I feel the Workshop would profit by: ensuring that the respective responsibilities and experience of participants is more uniform, treating long-onset and sudden disasters more distinctly according to participants needs, and that the schedule be lighter to make more individual work possible.

2. Cranfield Institute of Technology - Royal Military College of Science,
Shrivenham, 26 - 27 June 1985

2.1 ATLANTIS (a "computer-aided exercise for disaster relief management") was being run on 26-28 June as part of a middle management course for 10 military/defense ministry staff from seven developing countries. ATLANTIS has existed since 1977; UNDRO has had periodic contact with its creator, Lt.Col. Ritchie (ret.) who seeks wider use of the exercise and adoption/endorsement by disaster-related international organizations. He has recently proposed running the programme in Geneva in connexion with the monthly Steering Committee meeting of international agencies, has begun exploring collaboration with the ILO, and believes that ATLANTIS is likely to be adopted by the prospective AIT regional disaster centre. I observed the

exercise for a day and half, spoke on my impressions of the relevance of the exercise to disaster-management, and discussed possible areas of collaboration if UNDR0 were so interested.

2.2 None of the participants in the "game" I observed had disaster experience or responsibilities. The "Game Group" were all in one room exercising different ministerial responsibilities after a simulated earthquake. A Control Group, supported by a computer programme keeping track of available resources was in a separate room. The "Game Group" was monitored by a college staff member (psychologist) who both helped on procedural problems and monitored the group dynamics. Some interesting aspects were apparent which related to reality. For example although the participants were all in one room each tended to work only within their own ministerial contexts, reflecting the lack of inter-ministerial communications often seen in real life; similarly the participants were essentially reactive to the unfolding of the disaster, almost never anticipating or preparing for likely developments; despite the designation of a co-ordinator there was not a single entity responsible for keeping an overall picture up-to-date and making it known to all the participants.

2.3 I have made some observations by separate note on the possible usefulness of this exercise and of modelling in general. Modelling and gaming is commonly used in diverse professional and scientific activities (war gaming and business gaming are perhaps the best known). It seems logical that - especially with the advent of the micro-computer - gaming and modelling should find a place in disaster management. This has certainly been Lt.Col. Ritchie's contention for several years; it seems that his efforts are gaining ground and that UNDR0 could usefully associate itself to these or look into alternatives along similar lines. I note that the Royal Military College has recently come under civilian authority (Cranfield Institute of Technology).

3. Emergencies Unit-ODA, and British Council - London, 28 June

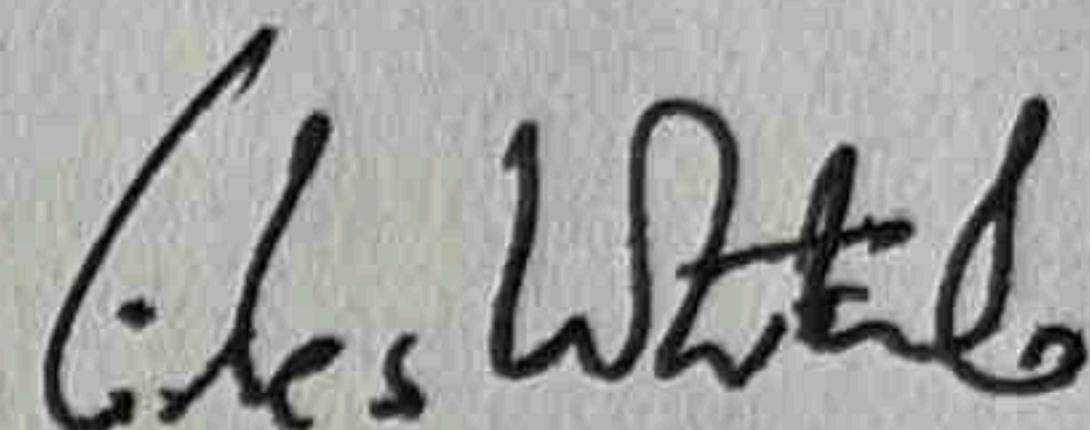
3.1 Miss Cherry was away when I visited the Emergencies Unit and I met with her deputy Mr. Emery. I reviewed some administrative details regarding the Unit's contribution to RICSU. (Mr. Russell had visited the Unit earlier in the week). The news of UNDR0's suspension of its activities in Africa has recently been received. Mr. Emery expressed his concern both over the difficulties the UN seemed to be experiencing in organizing and consolidating its emergency activities and over the prospective absence of UNDR0 Sitreps which the Unit valued.

3.2 I visited the British Council to thank the Sudan Desk Officer, Miss Anne Hewlin who had acted quickly and efficiently in arranging for partial sponsorship of Mr. El Mansour's participation at the Oxford Polytechnic Disaster Management Workshop. We also reviewed the question of reimbursement - UNDR0/RICSU having advanced funds to speed the process.

3.2.1 Discussions with Miss Hewlin indicated that though the British Council does not include disasters among its specialties, it can be interested in finding ways to support disaster management training. This

confirmed responses I had had from the British Council Office in Jakarta and Manila - where in addition to training, tentative commitments on providing specialized library and reference services had been made. The British Council is well disposed to supporting further participants at the Polytechnic Workshop (or elsewhere in the UK) though for any period less than three months, the support could not include the airfare.

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Giles Whitcomb

8 July 1985

GW/KB

cc: Mr. Essaafi
Mr. Einhaus
Mr. Dunn
Mr. Souria
Ms. Mengin
Registry